

100 Common English Idioms



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Idioms are phrases or proverbs whose meanings cannot be directly translated. Because of this, students must familiarize themselves with these phrases through a bit of memorization and practice.

While learning idioms might seem difficult and time-consuming, it'll help you to speak in more interesting ways and sound more natural among native English speakers. You'll also find learning idioms helpful for enjoying pop culture where many characters use idioms as they speak.

We've put together the 100 most common idioms, provided meanings and an example of each one being used in a sentence below. If you have a favorite idiom that we don't have on our list. Share it in the comments below!

1. Break the ice

Meaning: To get the conversation going. Provide a conversation prompt.

Example: Starting class with a joke or subjects students like will help to **break the ice**.

2. A dime a dozen

Meaning: Very common: quite ordinary

Example: I thought it was something special but it turns out they're **a dime a dozen**.

3. Beat around the bush

Meaning: To avoid saying something

Example: Don't **beat around the bush**. Just tell me what happened.

4. Back against the wall

Meaning: Forced to do something that you would rather not.

Example: I really don't want to do this but my **back is against the wall**.

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Meaning: To understand something that may take a bit of time and effort.

Example: That's really complicated. It's going to take a moment to **wrap my head around** that.

7. Under the weather

Meaning: Sick. Typically used to describe minor illnesses like a cold.

Example: Sorry I'm feeling a bit **under the weather** and won't be able to come in today.

8. Better late than never

Meaning: Describes things that are better done than not, even if it takes a long time.

Example: I went back to college at 30 years old and figured **better late than never**.

9. Cut corners

Meaning: To skip steps or not do things completely.

Example: This is an important project so don't **cut any corners** on this one.

10. Get out of hand

Meaning: When a situation gets out of control.

Example: I meant to just have a small party but too many people came and it quickly **got out of hand**.

11. A snowball effect

Meaning: Something that can continue to get more and more out of control

Example: I just invited a couple of people over but there was a bit of **a snowball effect** and now there's a giant party at my house.

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Example: **Cut me some slack.** I'm trying.

14. To be hard on someone

Meaning: To criticize or to manage someone very strictly.

Example: You don't have **to be so hard** on your employees to be successful.

15. Get something out of one's system

Meaning: To do something you really want to and have been waiting to.

Example: I really want to go to karaoke, sing a few songs and just **get it out of my system**.

16. Burn bridges

Meaning: To do something or anger someone to where you cannot go back to how things were and cannot expect help in the future.

Example: Don't **burn bridges** with your employer. You may need their help in the future.

17. Sell like hotcakes

Meaning: To sell very quickly or be in high demand.

Example: I didn't think my crafts would be that popular but they're **selling like hotcakes**.

18. Fish out of water

Meaning: To be in an unfamiliar or uncomfortable place.

Example: I don't want to change schools and be a **fish out of water**.

19. Step up one's game

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21. Leave out in the cold

Meaning: To be ignored or not considered.

Example: Not being invited to any of the meetings lately has me feeling **left out in the cold**.

22. Keep an ear to the ground

Meaning: To listen for new information.

Example: I'll **keep an ear to the ground** for any updates on the project.

23. Up in arms

Meaning: To be angry or overreact.

Example: Don't get **up in arms**. I'm just telling you what happened.

24. Run around in circles

Meaning: To put effort into something while making little or no progress.

Example: My boss has me **running around in circles** with unnecessary tasks that aren't getting us anywhere.

25. Scrape the barrel

Meaning: To make choices you don't want to or normally wouldn't.

Example: They're not great but I was really **scraping the barrel** to find something.

26. Blessing in disguise

Meaning: Something that seems bad but provides some benefit.

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Example: I thought he was definitely going to lose but he **had an ace up his sleeve** and caught up in points.

28. Buy it

Meaning: To believe something.

Example: That guy told me he's related to the president but I don't **buy it**.

29. Hook line and sinker

Meaning: To be deceived completely.

Example: I told him that I would pay him \$1,000,000 and he bought it **hook line and sinker**.

30. Piece of cake

Meaning: Very Easy.

Example: Winning the game is a **piece of cake** once you understand how to play.

31. Once in a blue moon

Meaning: Very rare.

Example: She doesn't like it here and only comes **once in a blue moon**.

32. On the line

Meaning: To risk something or have something at risk.

Example: I invested my life savings in this business and have everything **on the line**.

33. A quick buck

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Example: I have my **sights set on** going to France next year. | I **set my sights** on going to France next year.

35. Add fuel to the fire

Meaning: To make a situation worse.

Example: You should wait until later to say something. Sometimes arguing just **adds fuel to the fire**.

36. Bone to pick

Meaning: To be angry about something and want to discuss it.

Example: You might not think you did anything wrong but I have a **bone to pick** with you about that.

37. Go the extra mile

Meaning: To do extra work or put in extra effort.

Example: She **went the extra mile** and got our seats upgraded even though she didn't have to.

38. Hang in there

Meaning: To not give up.

Example: I know things are hard but **hang in there**.

39. Down for the count

Meaning: To give up or not be able to keep going.

Example: I tried everything and it took so much out of me. I'm **down for the count** on this one.

40. Rest on your laurels

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Example: I'm willing to **give it a whirl** even though I've never done it before.

42. It's not rocket science

Meaning: It's not as difficult as you might think.

Example: Of course, I figured it out. **It's not rocket science.**

43. Get bent out of shape

Meaning: To get upset at times when others don't think you should.

Example: Hey it's just a joke. Don't **get bent out of shape.**

44. Spill the beans

Meaning: To tell a secret.

Example: I already know you did it. Your best friend **spilled the beans.**

45. Sit on the fence

Meaning: To be undecided.

Example: I'm still **sitting on the fence** about whether I'm going to buy that car.

46. Don't cry over spilled milk/ No use in crying over spilled milk

Meaning: What has already happened cannot be undone so you shouldn't cry but you should think of what to do going forward.

Example: I know it wasn't your fault but there's **no use in crying over spilled milk.** Think of what you're going to do next.

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Meaning: To hear information directly from the person involved.

Example: I already know the truth. I heard **straight from the horse's mouth**.

49. Bigger fish to fry

Meaning: There is something more important to take care of.

Example: I can't think about that right now. I have **bigger fish to fry**.

50. At face value

Meaning: As something seems or as one claims it to be.

Example: Don't take what he says **at face value**. He's been known to lie.

51. Read between the lines

Meaning: To look for the real meaning when something is said.

Example: I don't just listen to what people tell me. I know how to **read between the lines**.

52. Wild goose chase

Meaning: To waste time trying to do something you cannot.

Example: My mom sent me on a **wild goose chase** trying to find things that aren't available anywhere.

53. Call it a day

Meaning: To stop working.

Example: Hey let's go home. It's time to **call it a day**.

54. Chip off the old block

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Example: Of course, he got into Harvard. **The apple doesn't fall far from the tree.**

56. In for a penny in for a pound

Meaning: To make sure a task is complete no matter what once someone has spent any effort or money towards the goal.

Example: I'm **in for a penny in for a pound** on this one. I've already spent seven hours getting this project off the ground.

57. By the skin of one's teeth

Meaning: To barely get something done.

Example: I passed that test **by the skin of my teeth** with a 61/100.

58. Draw the line

Meaning: To decide on a stopping past which you will not let something continue.

Example: I'm going to have to **draw the line here**. I can't do any more work until you pay your balance.

59. To not see/to lose the forest for the trees

Meaning: To fixate on trivial details to the point of ignoring the overall meaning or more important facts.

Example: Don't **lose the forest for the trees** here. The first few questions are only worth one point each so make sure you leave enough time for the open-ended questions.

60. Penny wise and pound foolish

Meaning: To worry about or obsess over unimportant details while ignoring the important ones.

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62. Play devil's advocate

Meaning: To present the other side or both sides of an argument.

Example: I just need you to support me, not to keep trying to **play devil's advocate**.

63. On thin ice

Meaning: In a dangerous or risky situation with much margin for error.

Example: I used 9 out of my 10 absences so my teacher told me I'm **on thin ice**.

64. The best thing since sliced bread

Meaning: Really, really good.

Example: The iPhone was **the best thing since sliced bread**. It really changed the world.

65. Take it with a pinch of salt

Meaning: Don't believe it to be 100% true.

Example: He lies a lot so **take what he says with a pinch of salt**.

66. The whole nine yards

Meaning: Everything to the greatest extent.

Example: I want everything on the menu. Appetizers, entrees, desserts, **the whole nine yards**.

67. Bite off more than you can chew

Meaning: To take on a task that is more difficult than you can handle.

Example: I regret agreeing to cook dinner for 100 people. I really **bit off more than I could chew**.

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Meaning: To improvise or wait for more information to come to a decision.

Example: I can't decide on what to do until I know what my manager's decision will be so I have to **play it by ear**.

70. Put something on ice

Meaning: To stop progress on something or put it on hold.

Example: Hey I need you to work on this project that's due today so you're going to have to **put what you're doing on ice**.

71. 24/7

Meaning: All the time, always. (24 hours a day, 7 days a week)

Example: I didn't invite him to my party because he's in medical school and studying **24/7**.

72. Lose one's touch

Meaning: To not be as good at something as one used to be.

Example: It took me 10 tries to get a basket. I'm really **losing my touch**.

73. Sit tight

Meaning: Please wait patiently.

Example: Hey I still have a few tasks to do before I can head out to dinner so **sit tight** and I'll be there soon.

74. Twist my arm

Meaning: To convince someone with persistence.

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76. Hit the books

Meaning: To study (more often used to imply studying hard)

Example: Final exams are coming up and I need a high score to maintain my A. I'm going to **hit the books** hard today.

77. Cold turkey

Meaning: To quit suddenly rather than gradually.

Example: If I start playing video games at all, I won't stop for hours so I had to quit **cold turkey**.

78. Go down in flames

Meaning: To fail suddenly and severely.

Example: A couple of scandals after her debut caused her career to **go down in flames**.

79. Pitch in

Meaning: To put in effort or to make a contribution.

Example: It's a lot of work but if everyone **pitches in**, we'll be done in no time.

80. Cut to the chase

Meaning: To get directly to the point.

Example: I'm in a rush so I need you to **cut to the chase** and just tell me what the problem is.

81. Off the table

Meaning: Unavailable, the offer has been revoked.

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Example: You waited too long and the job isn't available anymore. **That ship has sailed** so keep looking.

83. Blow off steam

Meaning: To do fun activities to help relieve stress.

Example: I had a long day at work and went to the batting cages to **blow off some steam**.

84. Come rain or shine

Meaning: No matter what.

Example: I promise, **come rain or shine**, I'll be at your graduation. You can count on it.

85. See eye to eye

Meaning: To agree, compromise or understand the other person's perspective.

Example: It's been six weeks and they can't come to any agreement because they just can't **see eye to eye**.

86. Rings a bell

Meaning: Sounds familiar or reminds you of something.

Example: What you just said **rings a bell**. There's this thing I forgot to tell you earlier.

87. A class act

Meaning: Of great character or able to perform to high standards.

Example: He puts on a good show every time and then shakes hands and takes pictures with fans. He's a real **class act**.

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Meaning: To be very expensive. (Typically less used for items less expensive than ones that you would use "break the bank" for).

Example: Replacing my broken car stereo **cost me an arm and leg**.

90. Face the music

Meaning: To accept reality.

Example: You failed every audition. It's time to **face the music** and accept that you're not a very good actor.

91. Darkest before the dawn

Meaning: Things will get better (Useful for when several bad things happen at once)

Example: I know that a lot of bad things happened to you this week but it's **darkest before the dawn**.

92. Through thick and thin

Meaning: Throughout good times and bad times.

Example: It doesn't matter if it's difficult or if bad things happen. I said I would help you **through thick and thin**.

93. Fortune favors the bold

Meaning: Taking a risk can pay off.

Example: There's only a 10% chance of success but the payout is 20 times higher if I win. You know what they say, **fortune favors the bold**.

94. Don't put all your eggs in one basket

Meaning: You're taking too big of a risk or putting too much effort and resources into one risky option

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Example: My parents told me not to put all my eggs in one basket but I decided to **throw caution to the wind** and be a full-time artist.

96. Look before you leap

Meaning: To think before you do something.

Example: The opportunity to move to another country is really exciting but I want you to **look before you leap**.

97. Jump on the bandwagon

Meaning: To follow a trend or not to do something until it's popular.

Example: She didn't care about K-pop before but now that it's popular, she's **jumped on the bandwagon**.

98. Pour one's heart out

Meaning: To tell or confess something emotional.

Example: I don't like soap operas. They're so unrealistic with the way everyone **pours their heart out** about everything.

99. Right as rain

Meaning: There is nothing that can be improved.

Example: The dish was **right as rain**. I wouldn't change a thing about it.

100. Pull one's leg

Meaning: To lie.

Example: That doesn't sound right. Are you pulling my leg?

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By: Welkin Tang

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**Freda** A day ago · 0 Likes

This is a very joyful day of my life because of the help PRIEST Salami has rendered to me by helping me get my ex-husband back with his magic and love spell. I was married for 6 years and it was so terrible because my husband was really cheating on me and was seeking a divorce but when I came across PRIEST Salami email on the internet on how he helped so many people to get their ex back and help to fix relationships. and make people happy in their relationship. I explained my situation to him and then sought his help but to my greatest surprise, he told me that he will help me with my case and here I am now celebrating because my Husband has changed totally for good. He always wants to be by me and can not do anything without my presence. I am really enjoying my marriage, what a great celebration. I will keep on testifying on the internet because PRIEST Salami is truly a real spell caster. DO YOU NEED HELP THEN CONTACT DOCTOR PRIEST Salami NOW VIA EMAIL: purenaturalhealer@gmail.com. Whatsapp number: +2348143757229 He is the only answer to your problem and makes you feel happy in your relationship...

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WHDI

6 days ago · 0 Likes

I feel like I have concrete blocks on my feet!



WHDI

6 days ago · 0 Likes

Don't be a sitting duck



solomon

A week ago · 0 Likes

Theses are helpful and take this plz whooper whooper



xd

A week ago · 0 Likes

Bro



Kamryn

A week ago · 0 Likes

HASHTAG
AMERICAAA



xd

A week ago · 0 Likes

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**DAKOTA** A week ago · 0 Likes

I got a bone to pick with you 🙄

**V** A week ago · 0 Likes

hi

**jodene** 2 weeks ago · 0 Likes

i love the idioms and now i will be able to spice up my pieces more
 and now i see that using idioms is not rocket science
 thank you it is really helpful!!

**Brianne** 3 weeks ago · 0 Likes

this helped me so much! i had to write an idiom poem for a class. This was so helpful! 5
 starssssssssssssss

**The rock** 3 weeks ago · 0 Likes

Mr fawcett is legend

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Idiom kinda sounds like idiot not gonna lie. Good page tho!



CHINA 4 weeks ago · 1 Like

MY FAVORITE IDIOM IS THE ONE ON FORTNITE



muwanguzi titus A month ago · 0 Likes

PLEASE ADD MORE FAMILIAR IDIOMS



kaoo A month ago · 0 Likes

suck a duck.



kaoo A month ago · 0 Likes

my comment is the cut above the rest.



Dog A month ago · 0 Likes

Choke the Chicken.

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Hi



riley A month ago · 0 Likes

hit the road



riley A month ago · 0 Likes

hit the hay



Zyo A month ago · 0 Likes

I love this...



Joshop49315@nbss.nbed.nb.ca 2 months ago · 0 Likes

What do these mean:

Chip on Your Shoulder

A Cut Below

Needle in a Haystack

Every Cloud Has a Silver Lining

a Lot on One's Plate

Dead as a doornail.

Chaos is a friend of mine.

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A cut below: of a lower quality than expected (Ex: This restaurant is a cut below what their prices indicate. Do you want to eat somewhere else?)

Needle in a haystack: something that's impossible or very difficult to find. (Ex: Finding her in this crowd will be like finding a needle in a haystack.)

Every cloud has a silver lining: Even bad scenarios have a positive outcome, however small. (Ex: It's unfortunate that you failed the class, but now you will know the basics when you retake it. Every cloud has a silver lining.)

A lot on one's plate: To be very busy and stressed (Ex: My boss assigned me three projects this week. I have a lot on my plate, so I won't be able to get lunch with you on Thursday).

Dead as a doornail: Emphasizing that somebody is dead. A bit informal and rude; I would not use this expression for people you liked/knew personally while they were alive. (Ex: Queen Elizabeth? Well now she's as dead as a doornail!)

Chaos is a friend of mine: I live in a chaotic environment and my lifestyle is chaotic (Ex: I have three toddlers in my house, so you can count on the fact that chaos is a friend of mine!)



Must 2 months ago · 1 Like

I thought it was gonna be good but it's actually a dime a dozen!



Duff 2 months ago · 1 Like

Where is mind your Ps and Qs



Samara 2 months ago · 1 Like

Really helped me specials for IEO exam..... 🥺🥺🥺🥺

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**Harka** 2 months ago · 0 Likes

Easier said than done

**ME** 2 months ago · 1 Like

THICK BRANDON

**Alexa** 2 months ago · 0 Likes

I am New to this program

**human gundam** 3 months ago · 0 Likes

helps with the nerve damag

**Alexa** 2 months ago · 0 Likes

you spelled damage w

**Charmaine** 3 months ago · 0 Likes

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**Inder rana** 3 months ago · 1 Like

Raining cats and dogs= heavy rain

**Ian Lopez** 4 months ago · 0 Likes

Now I know all the idioms 😊 By the way I'm in your house Here's a pet chicken 🐔 What is the spiders in your house 🕷️ 🕸️

**Ian Lopez** 4 months ago · 0 Likes

I'm leaving now

**GENG XINYAN** 4 months ago · 0 Likes

you are very nice! I am not kidding but you helped me pass my PSLE! now i can go to secondary1
thank you so much!

**Aiden** 4 months ago · 0 Likes

Didn't Help

**Scottish Fold** 4 months ago · 0 Likes

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Thank you guys very much .Actually helped me to pass my exams .God bless you



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